Affective History of Human-Cat Bonds: Transhistorical Continuity versus Historical Contingency

This report examines whether emotional bonds between humans and cats represent a transhistorical constant or culturally contingent relationships that vary across time and place. Drawing on affective history, animal studies, archaeology, and cross-cultural research, the analysis reveals a complex picture where universal biological mechanisms interact dynamically with historically specific cultural contexts, producing both striking continuities and profound differences.

The dual nature of human-cat emotional bonding

The evidence supports neither pure universalism nor absolute contingency. Instead, **human-cat bonds reflect biocultural entanglement**—where evolutionary psychology, neurochemistry, and ethology provide universal substrates that are activated, interpreted, and given meaning through culturally specific frameworks. Ancient Egyptians mourning cats by shaving their eyebrows, (Ancient Origins) Victorian Americans renting cats for companionship while traveling, and contemporary Japanese visiting cat cafes for "healing" all demonstrate emotional attachment, yet the quality, meaning, and social function of these bonds differ fundamentally across contexts.

Affective history provides the interpretive lens for understanding this complexity. As Rob Boddice argues, emotions are biocultural—neither purely biological universals nor entirely cultural constructs, but dynamic integrations where "culture and biology dynamically interact." (scielo) (Academia.edu) The neuroplasticity revealed by contemporary neuroscience validates what historians observe: cultural context literally shapes emotional experience, not just its expression. (scielo) (SciELO) Historical actors' feelings about their cats were authentically different across periods, not merely expressed differently.

Theoretical foundations in affective history and animal studies

Three principal frameworks structure the history of emotions: Barbara Rosenwein's "emotional communities" (groups sharing common emotional norms), William Reddy's "emotional regimes" (power structures imposing normative emotions), and Peter and Carol Stearns' "emotional styles" and "emotionology" (historically specific emotional expression patterns). (Wikipedia) Applied to cats, these reveal how societies establish acceptable emotional relationships with felines through shared standards, power dynamics, and cultural transmission.

The field emerged from fundamental debates about universalism versus constructivism. Early scholars asked whether emotions are "natural" biological universals or "nurtured" cultural constructs. Contemporary consensus rejects this binary. (Wikipedia) As Katie Barclay argues, emotions represent "radical anti-universalism"—substantially different across time—yet they operate through biological mechanisms that evolution shaped.

scielo The solution lies in bioculturality: human culture is itself part of natural evolution, with synaptic development occurring within cultural contexts.

Key animal studies scholars provide essential frameworks. **Harriet Ritvo's** seminal work established that Victorian pet-keeping reflected class structures, imperial domination, and social control. Cabinet Magazine +2 **Kathleen Kete** demonstrated how 19th century Parisians used pets to imagine better, more manageable worlds, with cats rehabilitated from "irascible and autonomous" to creatures of "fidelity and affection." Goodreads Google Books **Katherine C. Grier** documented how American pet-keeping between 1840-1940 established contemporary patterns, charting the transition from anonymous livestock to pets with individual "biographies." Amazon +2 **Erica Fudge** challenged traditional separation of humans from nature in historical writing, exploring animal agency and recovering animals' historical presence. H-Net +3

The "affective turn" in human-animal studies emphasizes embodied affectivity—using pre-reflective affective sensibility to understand animals' emotional and sensory lives through body-to-body interactions. Brill This approach, supported by neuroscience evidence of shared affective neural substrates across mammals, enables historians to engage with interspecies emotional bonds while maintaining critical distance.

Ancient Egypt: Sacred status and genuine attachment

Archaeological and textual evidence reveals complex relationships spanning practical, religious, and emotional dimensions. Ancient Origins The Egyptian case is particularly significant because it challenges assumptions that emotional pet-keeping is modern or Western, demonstrating sophisticated human-cat bonds 3,500 years ago.

Physical evidence is extensive. Massive cat cemeteries at Saqqara, Bubastis, and Beni Hasan contained hundreds of thousands of mummified cats from c. 1000 BCE onward. Wikipedia The Beni Hasan cemetery alone yielded over 200,000 cat mummies. Wikipedia Catster Cats received careful mummification with decorated linen wrappings, geometric patterns, and painted facial features. Some were placed in bronze or wooden sarcophagi with inscriptions ensuring safe passage to the afterlife. Wikipedia

The most famous example is **Ta Miu ("She-Cat")**, beloved companion of Prince Thutmose (c. 1391-1353 BCE). Ta Miu received a custom limestone sarcophagus with inscriptions: "I myself am placed among the imperishable ones that are in the Sky / For I am Ta-Miu, the Triumphant." This demonstrates individual recognition, naming, and investment in the cat's eternal existence—hallmarks of emotional attachment. Egypt Museum egypt-museum

The Berenice pet cemetery (1st-2nd century CE) provides particularly compelling evidence. Nearly 600 burials, over 90% cats, included animals wearing iron collars or necklaces of glass and shells. Ancient Origins Taylor & Francis Online Veterinary analysis revealed animals lived into old age, received care through injury and disease, and some had "very limited mobility" requiring special feeding. Ancient Origins Dr. Marta Osypińska concluded: "They weren't doing it for the gods or for any utilitarian benefit. The relationship between people and their pets was surprisingly close to what we see today." Science

Religious significance was profound. Bastet evolved from fierce lioness goddess (2nd Dynasty) to domestic cat deity embodying protection, fertility, and home (Late Period). Catster +2 The temple at Bubastis became Egypt's primary cat worship center, with festivals attracting hundreds of thousands of pilgrims. Wikipedia +2 However, religious significance and emotional bonds were not mutually exclusive—they reinforced each other within Egyptian cosmology where divine and natural integrated seamlessly.

Mourning practices demonstrate emotional investment. According to Herodotus, when household cats died naturally, family members shaved their eyebrows in visible grief, mourning until eyebrows grew back (several weeks). Ancient Origins +3 When buildings caught fire, Egyptians prioritized rescuing cats over fighting flames. TheCollector Killing a cat, even accidentally, was potentially capital. Diodorus Siculus recorded that in 60 BCE, a Roman soldier who accidentally killed a cat was lynched by an Egyptian mob despite pharaoh Ptolemy XII's intervention attempts. Wikipedia +4

Scholarly debate continues about interpretation. Dr. Michael MacKinnon notes seaports "teemed with rats," making cats valuable working animals, questioning whether relationships were "just loving." However, Dr. Bea De Cupere argues: "I don't think you can draw a straight line between a utilitarian and a companion animal. I don't think you can separate the two." A cat catching vermin daily leads people to appreciate it, then develop emotional bonds, making separation of motivations artificial. Atlas Obscura Fellinis

The emerging consensus acknowledges **multiple, overlapping motivations**: practical utility (pest control), religious significance (vessels of Bastet), and genuine emotional attachment (companionship, mourning, individual care). The relative weight varied by time period (later periods emphasized religion), social class (elites afforded elaborate pet burials), and individual relationships.

Late nineteenth century United States: Victorian sentimentality and middle-class identity

The period 1870-1900 witnessed fundamental transformation in American human-cat relationships from utilitarian mousers to emotionally significant household companions. This shift paralleled Victorian domestic culture, middle-class formation, industrialization, and the "ethic of kindness."

Mark Twain exemplifies documented emotional bonds. He owned up to 19 cats simultaneously with creative names: Apollinaris, Beelzebub, Blatherskite, Buffalo Bill, Satan, Sin, Sour Mash, Tammany, Zoroaster. Famous quotes demonstrate attachment: "A home without a cat—and a well-fed, well-petted and properly revered cat—may be a perfect home, perhaps, but how can it prove title?" When traveling, Twain rented cats for companionship. In 1906 in Dublin, New Hampshire, he rented three kittens, treating them royally with "grave politeness." When his cat Bambino went missing in 1905, Twain placed a $5 reward advertisement ($150 today) with detailed physical descriptions, demonstrating emotional investment and public acknowledgment of the cat's value.

The rise of cat fancy institutionalized emotional bonds. Following Harrison Weir's 1871 Crystal Palace show in England, which "ushered in a new era of appreciation," Atlas Obscura American shows began. The pivotal moment was Madison Square Garden, May 8-11, 1895: 176 cats exhibited by 125 owners competing for $1,000 in prizes. Alley Cat Allies +3 Winner "Cosey," a brown tabby Maine Coon, became celebrated. THE GREAT CAT Despite temperatures reaching 96°F testing both cats and owners, extensive attendance demonstrated commitment. Cat shows provided public venues for displaying affection, competing for recognition, and building communities around shared cat love.

Cat clubs formalized communities. The Beresford Cat Club (Chicago, 1899), most successful early American club, had 170 members by 1900, held annual shows with 170+ prizes, established cat homes for stray and homeless cats, and created children's clubs teaching kindness to animals. This institutionalized the "ethic of kindness" that Katherine C. Grier identifies as central to this period.

Cultural context was essential. Victorian "cult of domesticity" positioned homes as idealized sacred spaces responding to industrial cities' growth. Pets became socially acceptable and central to constructing Victorian domestic ideals. Mansfieldct-history +3 Pet-keeping demonstrated middle-class values, teaching children empathy and moral values. The Conversation Encyclopedia.com Grier's research shows that between 1820-1870, Americans became convinced of animals' role in socializing children, making training children to be self-conscious about kindness an important parenting task. Amazon Brill

Social class mattered profoundly. Wealthy fanciers like Mrs. Clinton Locke (first to import Persian cats) and Mrs. Leland Norton owned highly valued cats. Cats were imported from England for $100-$300 each (equivalent to $3,000-$9,000 today). Persianbc However, working-class families also kept cats, though documentation is scarcer due to literacy and archival bias. Their cats often served multiple functions—companionship plus mousing—operating within different economic constraints and spatial arrangements. Taylor & Francis Online

Gender dimensions were significant. Cats became associated with domestic femininity and women. Dogs traveled outside with owners for "masculine activities like hunting," while cats had "particular affinity for the home." Biodiversitylibrary +2 Victorian "Cat Ladies" emerged as both stereotype and reality. Frances Simpson (1857-1926), professional cat expert and breeder, remained single by choice, becoming a leading expert through "subject knowledge, stellar reputation and tireless dedication." MessyBeast Racing Nellie Bly However, spinsters with cats were stigmatized as "failures," represented as "oversexed, undersexed, adorable, anti-social, self-absorbed, fanatical, witches, and wantons." Victorian Web

Attitudes toward cats improved but remained ambivalent. The Chicago Tribune (March 17, 1895) noted "Although not generally esteemed... the tide is now setting in another direction." PetMD Yet cats were still viewed as inferior to dogs. Nathaniel Southgate Shaler (1895) called cats "the least essential, and on the whole the least interesting, of domesticated animals" serving as "capital foil by which to set off the virtues of the dog."

Biodiversitylibrary biodiversitylibrary Dorothy Champion (1909) countered prevailing belief, arguing "an uneducated cat has far more brains than an uneducated dog." Biodiversitylibrary biodiversitylibrary

Twenty-first century Japan: Healing culture and economic integration

Contemporary Japan demonstrates how ancient cultural traditions, socioeconomic pressures, and modern consumer culture create distinctive emotional bonds shaped by urbanization, aging society, and concepts of kawaii (cuteness) and iyashi (healing).

Cat cafes epitomize the "healing boom." The phenomenon peaked in 2009, emerging from the "healing boom" (iyashi) that began in recessionary 1990s Japan. Academia.edu +4 Lorraine Plourde's research shows cat cafes represent "affective labor"—commodified intimacy designed to cope with economic and social anxieties. The first Japanese cat cafe opened in Osaka (2004), Tokyo (2005), with approximately 40+ cafes in Tokyo metropolitan area by 2015. Cat cafes function as "third places"—neither home nor work—providing social refuge in dense urban environments. They're designed to evoke home-like atmosphere through furniture, lighting, and background music. Primary clientele are urban residents unable to keep pets due to housing restrictions and those seeking stress relief.

"Nekonomics" demonstrates unprecedented economic integration. Professor Katsuhiro Miyamoto coined the term in 2015 as wordplay on "Abenomics." Broad Street Review The cat-related economy was valued at ¥1.9 trillion ($14.6 billion) in 2021—exceeding Tokyo 2020 Olympics costs—with 2025 projections of ¥2.9 trillion. Wikipedia The Costa Rica News Components include pet food, veterinary care, cat cafes, tourism (cat islands), merchandise, and media content. The famous example is Tama the Station Master, a stray cat appointed station master at Kishi Station (Wakayama) in 2007, contributing ¥1.1 billion to the local economy. After death (2015), Tama was enshrined as a Shinto deity, with successors continuing the tradition. Wikipedia

Practical factors explain cat popularity. Average Japanese urban apartments are under 700 square feet. Many rental properties prohibit dogs but may overlook cats. Cats require less space, no outdoor areas, and minimal daily time commitment, suiting demanding Japanese work culture. J-Life International Cat ownership surpassed dog ownership by 2014-2016. By 2023, Japan had 9.07 million pet cats versus 6.84 million dogs (43.6% of total pets), with pets outnumbering children under 15 (15.91 million pets vs. 13.7 million children). Grand View Research

Aging society and social isolation drive attachment. Japan is a super-aged society with world's second-highest proportion of people 65+. Frontiers PubMed Central Approximately 30,000 "lonely deaths" (kodokushi) occur annually among elderly. A 2016 study of Ota Ward, Tokyo, found 32% of Japanese are socially isolated. Research shows socially isolated older adults with dog/cat ownership experience better psychological health. PubMed Central Pets serve as child substitutes for an aging, declining fertility society. Animal-assisted therapy proves effective for hikikomori (socially withdrawn individuals).

Cultural foundations differ from Western contexts. Buddhist and Shinto traditions view pets as sentient beings capable of rebirth (Buddhism) and potential kami/spirits (Shintoism). Confucian emphasis on symbiosis between humans and animals extends benevolence to animals. Wikipedia Historically, cats protected Buddhist scriptures from rodents (introduced ~6th century). During the Heian period (794-1185), cats were highly valued luxury items exchanged among nobility. Emperor Uda (889 CE) documented receiving a kitten gift, describing behavior in detail. Some aristocrats bestowed court ranks on cats. Nippon.com Wikipedia

Kawaii culture shapes perception. Kawaii—translating as "cute" but encompassing broader aesthetic of youthful innocence, charm, vulnerability—originated in 1970s among university students and became national cultural export. Cats epitomize neotenic features valued in kawaii aesthetic: small size, soft fur, large eyes, playful behavior. Hello Kitty (created 1974, deliberately mouthless to allow emotional projection) became world's second-highest grossing franchise. Wikipedia Wikipedia Kawaii represents non-threatening, innocent aesthetic particularly valued in post-WWII "soft power" cultural projection.

Mourning practices demonstrate deep attachment. The pet funeral industry boomed since 2000s, with approximately 100 firms in Kanto region. Services include individual cremation (¥15,000-114,800), Buddhist sutra readings (¥40,000), flower altars (¥30,000), and musicians. Mobile cremation services visit homes. Some temples provide full funeral rites identical to human services. Deseret News Annon ("peace/tranquility") services see Buddhist priests conduct same services for pets as humans. Forty-nine-day death anniversaries are observed (traditional Buddhist mourning period). Pet memorial tablets are placed at family altars, integrating pets into ancestor veneration. Wikipedia Over 70% of pet owners desire graves/memorials; over 60% prefer individual funerals versus communal disposal. Lonite

Cross-cultural studies reveal differences. Recent research (Anthrozoös, 2024) comparing US and Japan found US pet cats and cafe cats spend more time in proximity to humans than Japanese counterparts. Owner attachment is high in both countries, but attachment predicts cat sociability in the US, not Japan. Taylor & Francis Online Taylor & Francis Online Japanese owners relate to cats more emotionally with less knowledge of animal behavior compared to Western owners. Japanese view dogs and cats as equally important (both associated with spirit world), while Western owners differentiate more between species. A 2018 study found Japanese attribute surprisingly high levels of "compassion" to cats (73.1%)—uncommon in Western studies—explained by collectivist mentality understanding animal emotions contextually within situational factors. PubMed Central nih

Arguments supporting transhistorical continuity

Multiple scholarly perspectives argue that fundamental human-cat bonding mechanisms transcend cultural contexts, rooted in evolutionary psychology, neurobiology, and universal human needs.

Evolutionary psychology provides biological foundations. John Archer (1997) proposes that pets "manipulate human responses that had evolved to facilitate human relationships, primarily those between parent and child."

Pets act as "social parasites" that have "broken the code" of human parenting reactions through Darwinian exploitation. (ScienceDirect) This mechanism is universal, not culturally specific. E.O. Wilson's "biophilia hypothesis" (1984) proposes humans possess an "innate tendency to focus on life and lifelike processes" and "innate emotional affiliation with other living organisms." This genetic basis is part of human evolutionary heritage, with human dependence on nature extending "far beyond simple material and physical sustenance to encompass aesthetic, intellectual, cognitive, and even spiritual meaning." If biophilia is genetically encoded, it represents a transhistorical constant predating cultural differences.

Baby schema theory explains universal attraction. Konrad Lorenz (1943) identified the "baby schema" (Kindchenschema)—infantile features (large forehead, large eyes, rounded features) triggering innate caregiving responses, described as an "innate releasing mechanism." (Frontiers +3) Contemporary research demonstrates this applies transhistorically and cross-species. Cats exhibit morphological and behavioral infantile characteristics retained into adulthood through domestication (neoteny). These features "form the basis of our attraction to animals, especially pets." (Today's Veterinary Nurse) Research by Borgi and Cirulli (2014) shows baby schema response is documented from age 3-6 in children and persists throughout life, extending across species boundaries—humans respond similarly to infant features in humans, dogs, and cats. Little (2012) demonstrated that manipulating baby-schema features in cat faces affects perceived cuteness similarly to manipulating human infant faces. (Frontiers) This response is biologically innate, cross-cultural, cross-species, and evolutionarily ancient.

Attachment theory reveals universal patterns. John Bowlby's attachment theory, originally for parent-child relationships, extends successfully to human-pet relationships with similar patterns. (ScienceDirect +2) Zilcha-Mano, Mikulincer and Shaver developed the Pet Attachment Questionnaire showing pets serve attachment functions: safe haven and secure base. (ScienceDirect) (ScienceDirect) Landmark research by Vitale, Behnke and Udell (2019) demonstrated cats display distinct attachment styles toward humans—65% secure, 35% insecure—proportions similar to human infants (65%) and dogs (58%). This reveals cats "show a similar capacity for the formation of secure and insecure attachments towards human caregivers." (Cell Press) Attachment is an evolutionary adaptation present across mammalian species, part of "ultimate human nature" that transcends culture.

Oxytocin provides neurochemical substrate. Multiple studies demonstrate oxytocin release during human-cat interactions. Cat-initiated contact correlates with increased oxytocin in humans, mirroring mother-infant bonding mechanisms and suggesting "hormonal synchrony between the dyad." Brief petting sessions boost oxytocin, creating "self-perpetuating oxytocin-mediated positive loop similar to mother-infant bonds." (HABRI) (PetMD) This mechanism operates across species boundaries. Research shows securely attached cats show oxytocin increases during owner interaction, with different attachment styles correlating with different oxytocin patterns. Oxytocin is a conserved neurochemical system present in all mammals, providing a physiological substrate for emotional bonds that is universal.

Cross-cultural evidence shows commonalities. Dennis C. Turner's research examined attitudes and behaviors toward cats across countries with different economic status and religious backgrounds. Despite cultural differences, fundamental patterns of attachment persist. The Companion Animal Bonding Scale shows cross-cultural validity, with pet attachment correlating with attitudes across diverse cultural contexts. HABRI US-Japan comparative studies (2024) found owners in both countries show high levels of attachment to cats, with pet cats demonstrating similar social behaviors toward owners in both cultures. Taylor & Francis Online Taylor & Francis Online Differences exist but fundamental bonding mechanisms are present in culturally distinct societies (Western individualistic vs. East Asian collectivist), suggesting underlying universal mechanisms.

Archaeological evidence demonstrates continuity. Cats and dogs were buried with humans over 12,000 years ago. PETS Clinic Cat burials in ancient Cyprus date to approximately 9,500 years ago. Egypt Museum +4 Ancient burial sites in many parts of world reveal close animal-human bonds over millennia. In Peru, Chiribaya people buried dogs with blankets and food alongside humans. ResearchGate Religious traditions (Judaism, Islam, Christianity) placed importance on proper animal treatment. This evidence extending throughout recorded history and across diverse civilizations suggests fundamental continuity.

Scholars taking universalist positions argue that while cultural and historical contexts shape the expression of human-cat bonds, the capacity and fundamental mechanisms for such bonds are rooted in universal human biology and psychology transcending specific cultural moments. The emotional bond draws on ancient, conserved psychological and biological systems rather than being culturally constructed anew in each context.

Arguments emphasizing historical and cultural contingency

Extensive scholarship demonstrates that human-cat emotional bonds are profoundly shaped by specific social, cultural, historical, and economic contexts, challenging essentialist or biological deterministic views.

Cross-cultural variations are radical. Jeffrey Vadala's analysis using the eHRAF World Cultures database documents dramatic variations. Islamic societies revere cats as sacred animals—Muhammad forbade their killing; belief that caring for cats helps reach heaven. Persian culture views cats as omens, both good (cat washing means guest coming) and bad (cat rubbing face signals danger), with black cats as djinn/genies. Rural Thailand uses cats in rain-making rituals, soaking them with water as "sympathetic magic" to end droughts. Maya Yucatan believes in "uay-miz" (cat sorcerer)—shape-shifting humans transforming into cats for mischief. Azande (Central Africa) fear wild cats as deadly omens associated with witchcraft. Human Relations Area Files yale These variations demonstrate cats are "regarded quite differently in cultures around the world"—as messengers of good omens, bad omens, magical beings, genies, or sorcerers.

Historical shifts reveal constructed nature of attitudes. The transformation from Egyptian veneration to medieval persecution to Victorian sentimentality demonstrates emotional attitudes are not natural or universal but constructed through religious ideology, power relations, and social anxieties. During Egyptian veneration (pre-3150 BCE - 30 BCE), cats were associated with goddesses Isis and Bastet, killing cats was forbidden, and

families mourned by shaving eyebrows. (Human Relations Area Files +2) Medieval European persecution (12th-17th centuries) saw Pope Gregory IX's 1233 bull Vox in Rama establish association between cats and devil. (Catster) Pope Innocent VIII declared in 1484 that "the cat was the devil's favourite animal and idol of all witches." (Cats Luv Us) Three centuries of "brutal feline persecution" followed (1200s-1500s). (Catster +2) Irina Metzler argues medieval cat persecution was specifically about their "association with heresy and resistance to Christian social order." Medieval anxiety stemmed from cats' "independent nature"—they cannot be trained to be loyal like dogs, threatening hierarchical worldviews. As Metzler notes: "Medieval people generally believed that animals were created by God to serve and be ruled by humans, but the cat, even when domesticated, cannot be trained to be loyal and obedient like a dog." (Medievalists)

Victorian pet-keeping was historically specific invention. Harriet Ritvo's seminal work argues modern pet-keeping as we know it is a Victorian invention shaped by specific historical forces. Pet-keeping was transformed into a marker of class status and social aspiration. Animals served as "metaphors for human psychological needs and sociopolitical aspirations." Victorian thinking about animals must be understood in context of evolution, class structure, popular science, and imperial domination. (Project MUSE +3) Pedigree breeding reflected class hierarchies and efforts at social control. (Wikipedia) Andrew Robichaud shows 19th century witnessed "banishment of productive animals" from cities. Modern pet culture is a "legacy of this late-19th-century historical moment," revealing "deep contradictions in the ways we treat animals as a society." (Boston University) What we recognize as modern pet keeping—"an approach characterized by keeping animals for no other purpose than to be companions for humans"—emerged during late 18th and early 19th centuries. (Amazon) Prior to that time, animals cared for by humans had functions or tasks within households. (OpenStax)

Social class profoundly shapes relationships. Victorian pet culture varied dramatically by class. Middle classes used pedigree dogs as "fashion to display their status in city life." Pet-keeping became inscribed within bourgeois culture by 19th century. (ScienceDirect) (Wikipedia) Working-class pet-keeping was qualitatively different and often dismissed by middle-class observers. Histories of human-animal companionship have been "skewed towards the middle and upper classes," creating the risk of "establishing middle-class values and practices as the norm, creating the implicit assumption that working-class difference amounts to deviance." (Taylor & Francis Online) Working-class pet-keeping involved different spatial arrangements, economic constraints, and affective practices. A 2024 Chinese urban study demonstrates pet ownership is "closely related to social-economic status of a household," with higher income households more likely to have pets. (ScienceDirect) Modern pets "replaced families and friends to provide people with emotional security" during urbanization, but this is a specifically modern phenomenon. (ScienceDirect)

Gender constructs emotional relationships. Victorian pet culture was heavily gendered. Monica Flegel shows spinsters with cats were stigmatized as "failures," represented as "oversexed, undersexed, adorable, anti-social, self-absorbed, fanatical, witches, and wantons." Bachelors with pets were viewed negatively but less harshly. Pet relationships both "regulate and defy boundaries of species, gender, sexuality, and class." (Victorian Web) Contemporary associations persist: "Owning a dog is masculine and owning a cat is feminine." Men who own

cats face stigma: "we think men with cats are a little femmy or, at minimum, sweeter than most… even, maybe, gay." (The Society Pages) These associations are culturally constructed, not natural.

Religious and ideological frameworks determine meanings. The shift from Islamic veneration (based on Prophet Muhammad's example) to Christian persecution (based on theological constructions of cats as heretical/demonic) demonstrates that emotional attitudes are constructed through religious ideology rather than natural responses. Different religious traditions create entirely different emotional possibilities and constraints.

Critical animal studies challenges universalism. The movement emphasizes intersectionality, drawing "attention to common roots of many forms of oppression, such as speciesism, sexism, racism." It questions "the notion that academic analysis can be entirely objective, devoid of normative values and political commitments," emphasizing how human-animal relations are embedded in "global systems of domination." (Wikipedia) Multispecies anthropology argues human-cat relationships cannot be reduced to biology or simple adaptation but involve complex co-construction through "different historical contexts of agriculture, religion, colonization, and urbanization."

Archaeological evidence shows changing relationships. Fiona Marshall's research documents a progression from commensal to domestic relationships taking thousands of years and varying by region. Neolithic cats had commensal relationships in agricultural landscapes, hunting independently. Roman cats show isotopic signatures similar to humans and dogs, suggesting they were "probably fed by their owners." By 4,000 years ago in Egypt, "art and writing indicate that domestic cats played a role in family life and state religion." (NCBI +2) This progression challenges any notion of a single, universal domestication process.

Scholars emphasizing contingency argue that treating human-cat relationships as natural, universal, or biologically determined obscures the specific social, economic, and ideological forces shaping these bonds in different contexts. The field demands contextualist, intersectional, and historically specific analyses recognizing both human agency in constructing meanings and animal agency in co-creating relationships within specific historical circumstances.

Comparative analysis: reconciling perspectives

The apparent contradiction between transhistorical and contingency arguments resolves through recognizing different analytical levels and questions being addressed.

Universal mechanisms with culturally specific expressions. The oxytocin bonding system, baby schema responses, and attachment capacities represent evolutionarily conserved mechanisms present across human populations. However, these mechanisms are activated, interpreted, and given meaning through cultural frameworks. An Ancient Egyptian experiencing oxytocin release while petting a cat interpreted this within cosmology linking cats to Bastet and divine protection. A Victorian American experienced similar neurochemistry but interpreted it through middle-class domesticity and moral improvement. A contemporary Japanese person experiences it within iyashi (healing) discourse responding to economic recession and social

isolation. The physiological substrate is similar; the phenomenological experience and cultural meaning differ profoundly.

Historical periodization matters. Scholars arguing for transhistoricity often work at evolutionary timescales (thousands to millions of years), while those emphasizing contingency work at historical timescales (decades to centuries). At evolutionary timescales, human capacity for interspecies attachment is relatively stable. At historical timescales, the forms, meanings, and social functions of these attachments transform dramatically. Both perspectives are valid at their respective scales.

Power relations and inequality shape access. Biological capacity for bonding with cats may be universal, but ability to act on this capacity is historically contingent. Working-class Victorians may have felt attachment to cats but lacked resources for elaborate pet-keeping practices. Gender norms constrained which people could acceptably express cat attachment. Religious persecution made emotional bonding with cats literally dangerous in medieval Europe. Thus, contingency arguments reveal how power structures enable or constrain expression of potentially universal capacities.

Cat agency and human interpretation interact. Cats possess species-typical behaviors—neotenic features, communication patterns, social flexibility—that consistently elicit human responses. However, how humans interpret these behaviors varies radically. Egyptian priests interpreted cat behavior as divine communication. Medieval inquisitors interpreted identical behaviors as demonic. Victorian sentimentalists interpreted them as moral exemplars. Contemporary Japanese interpret them as kawaii. The cat's behavior is relatively constant; human interpretive frameworks transform its meaning.

Methodological pluralism is necessary. Neuroscience, evolutionary psychology, and ethology reveal universal substrates. History, anthropology, and sociology reveal cultural specificity. Both are necessary for comprehensive understanding. As Barbara Rosenwein notes in addressing the universalism-constructivism debate, most scholars now reject binaries, embracing biocultural synthesis where biological constraints operate but cultural contexts shape emotional experience itself.

The Anglo-Saxon case study illustrates integration. Research on "The Contextual Cat" in Anglo-Saxon England demonstrates this synthesis. Cats possess "relational agency"—ability to "act back"—that makes human-animal interactions "extremely dynamic." However, "the types of animals that people interacted with, and the level of engagement, would have heavily depended on human social identity, including status, gender and religious affiliation." Individual naming practices (like Old Irish cat names "Méone"—"little meow," "Cruibne"—"little paws") suggest "recognition of certain aspects of a particular individual animal's character or behaviour," setting "these individual cats apart from the other, nameless and ownerless, cats." Springer This reveals both universal capacity for recognizing animal individuality and culturally specific practices of naming and kinship.

Serpell's work synthesizes perspectives. James Serpell's research on "Pet-Keeping in Non-Western Societies" demonstrates that "the practice of capturing, taming, and keeping wild animals for companionship is widespread among hunting and gathering and simple horticultural societies," yet "affection for pets within such societies is largely independent of economic considerations." ResearchGate Among the Barasana of Colombia, pet-keeping is "not motivated by any practical or economic considerations. These people simply enjoy looking after and caring for their pets. The animals are a continual source of discussion and entertainment." The Evergreen State College This suggests both universal human propensity for animal companionship and culturally specific meanings and practices.

Synthesis: toward biocultural understanding

The evidence supports a **biocultural model** where universal biological mechanisms and culturally specific contexts dynamically interact to produce both continuities and transformations in human-cat emotional bonds.

Continuities across time and culture include:

- Capacity for attachment formation (secure/insecure patterns similar across populations)
- Neurochemical bonding mechanisms (oxytocin responses to touch and co-habitation)
- Response to neotenic features (baby schema triggering caregiving across cultures)
- Individual recognition and naming of companion cats
- Mourning practices when cats die (though forms vary)
- Integration of cats into family structures (though structures vary)

Contingencies varying by context include:

- Meanings attributed to human-cat relationships (sacred vessels, demonic familiars, moral exemplars, healing commodities)
- Social acceptability and prestige of cat-keeping (veneration, persecution, stigma, celebration)
- Gender norms around cat attachment (feminine-coded in Victorian West, more balanced in ancient Egypt)
- Class dimensions of pet-keeping (elite pedigrees, working-class utility, middle-class morality)
- Economic integration and commercialization (from minimal to multi-billion dollar industries)
- Religious interpretations (Buddhist rebirth, Christian demonization, Islamic reverence, Shinto enshrinement)
- Spatial arrangements (urban apartments, Victorian parlors, ancient temples, rural farms)

The key insight from affective history: Emotions are not expressions of underlying universal feelings, nor are they entirely cultural constructs with no biological basis. Rather, emotions are **biocultural processes** where

evolutionary inheritance provides possibilities and constraints, while cultural contexts shape how these possibilities are realized. The neuroplasticity revealed by contemporary neuroscience validates this: repeated cultural practices literally reshape neural architecture, meaning historical actors' emotional experiences were authentically different, not just expressed differently.

As Rob Boddice argues, "to say that emotions change over time is incompatible with claims that there is something fundamentally transcendent or 'basic' about emotions." Yet Boddice also advocates for synthesizing neuroscience insights, which show that cultural context changes the quality of emotion itself. The resolution is recognizing that biological substrates exist but are always already embedded in cultural contexts that shape their development and expression from infancy onward.

Harriet Ritvo's warning remains crucial: We must examine attitudes "in the context of other lines of thought: evolution, class structure, popular science and natural history, imperial domination." Treating human-cat bonds as natural or universal obscures the power relations, social inequalities, and ideological structures shaping which humans can bond with cats, how these bonds are interpreted, and what social functions they serve.

Yet universalist scholars provide important correctives to pure constructivism. The capacity for interspecies attachment did not emerge de novo in the Victorian period—it has deep evolutionary roots. Archaeological evidence spanning 12,000 years reveals this capacity being exercised across diverse cultures. The neurochemical and psychological mechanisms enabling bonding are genuinely transhistorical in the sense that they are part of human evolutionary inheritance.

Conclusion: beyond false dichotomies

The question of whether human-cat emotional bonds are transhistorical or historically contingent presents a false dichotomy. The evidence demands more sophisticated analysis recognizing multiple levels of causation and meaning.

At the level of biological capacity: Humans possess evolutionarily conserved mechanisms for interspecies attachment, including oxytocin bonding systems, responses to neotenic features, and attachment formation capacities. These are relatively stable across populations and time periods, providing a substrate for human-cat relationships.

At the level of phenomenological experience: The feeling of loving a cat—what it is like subjectively—varies profoundly across historical contexts. An Ancient Egyptian's love for their cat, a Victorian American's affection, and a contemporary Japanese person's attachment are qualitatively different experiences shaped by different cosmologies, social structures, emotional regimes, and available cultural scripts.

At the level of social meaning and function: Human-cat relationships serve radically different purposes across contexts—religious devotion, pest control, moral education, status display, therapeutic healing, commercial entertainment. These meanings are constructed through specific historical forces and power relations.

At the level of accessibility and practice: Who can bond with cats, how bonds are expressed, what resources are available for pet-keeping, and what social consequences follow from cat attachment all vary dramatically by historical period, culture, social class, gender, and other axes of identity.

The most productive approach integrates insights from both perspectives. **From transhistorical arguments**, we learn that human capacity for emotional bonds with cats has deep evolutionary roots, operates through conserved neurobiological mechanisms, and appears across diverse human societies. **From contingency arguments**, we learn that this capacity is always realized within specific historical contexts that profoundly shape its expression, meaning, and social function.

Affective history provides the framework for this integration. As the field has matured, it has moved beyond simple nature-nurture debates to embrace bioculturality—recognizing that human emotional life is simultaneously evolved and culturally constructed, with culture itself as part of natural evolutionary processes. The history of emotions challenges basic emotions models not by denying biological substrates but by showing how cultural contexts shape emotional experience itself through neuroplasticity and developmental processes.

The cat emerges as perfect subject for exploring these questions. Cats' relative independence compared to dogs, their liminal status between wild and domestic, their varied cultural meanings (sacred, demonic, cute, healing), and their 10,000-year entanglement with humans make them ideal for examining how universal capacities and cultural specificities interact. As Kathleen Kete observed, "even the irascible, autonomous cat had been rehabilitated into a creature of fidelity and affection" by the late 19th century—a transformation that was neither inevitable nor merely illusory, but represented genuine historical change in emotional relationships.

For scholars of affective history, the lesson is clear: we must resist both biological reductionism that treats emotions as timeless universals and cultural constructivism that denies material and biological realities. Instead, we must trace how specific historical actors—both human and feline—created emotional relationships within particular contexts, recognizing that these relationships drew on evolutionary inheritances while producing genuinely novel configurations of feeling, meaning, and practice.

The human love for cats is simultaneously ancient and ever-new—rooted in evolutionary psychology yet transformed by each historical moment's unique constellation of economic systems, power relations, religious beliefs, gender norms, and cultural values. This is not a paradox to resolve but a complexity to embrace as we work toward richer, more nuanced understandings of how humans and animals have shared emotional lives across the millennia.